

To Those among us, who discuss us, and have no love for us

We idolize those who are living in a disguise through their own reprise
My ancestors lived off the land, now you wanna group us all into bands/ all while ignoring all our demands

Cant oppress me I am a warrior, crowns got my nation being treated like a foreigner
Its real, since the creation, they have been moving us from location to location
All the while, saving the good allocation, for those whom now want to say they have no obligation

Our rights are affirmed and recognized, our ancestors were presented this as if it were a prize,
Not knowing the crowns tendency to lie

Little did they know we would be living subsidized

How can you look at us with such hate, and then expect us to believe you will fairly negotiate

Trying to buy us off with the monetized paper, just so you can be the lands raper

I see my people staying loyal to the land, while others want to meet the oil market demand

First out here

We are not considered equal, they still want to displace my people

All that we see in hollywood, is ever represented by those who have a tough time in manhood

Its not innate for us to compete and dominate

Our culture is not a costume, i just want back my family's heirlooms

Justin Trudeau was tryna play games, Jody Wilson-Raybould was not about his fame

Legal profession claims they wanna see us out of oppression, but i'm out here stressin and investin, just tryna be the best dressin

Everytime i put on a suit i feel further and further from my roots,

The way we girls are preyed upon should constitute some notion in the institute

Yea, Its no wonder many of our women turn a trick and prostitute

Everytime I turn on the news, missing and murdered Indigenous women

And then I hear Adam Palmer tryna be dismissing

Defending and tryna diffuse

But we are still out here reminiscing, about all those who were abused

Got to remember I am a blessin, cant still be stressin

People wanna say I look white, I laugh because they dont know my fight

So i will go get my JD and live lavish, for all those who called me a fucking savage

Indigenous Hip-Hop in Canada

To Those among us, who discuss us, and have no love for us

Throughout my life I have found that Canadians are constantly shining a light on the “Indian” problem. There has always been a certain distance kept between Indigenous and non Indigenous Canadians from the way in which mainstream Canadian media oppresses Indigenous peoples. I have found that Indigenous people are largely broadcast as a political issue, not necessarily as a group of constituents. I cannot help but read comments on social media on these sorts of issues, and see the blatant lack of respect. I reflect my views of the Canadian mainstream media in addressing this in the first line of my piece.

We idolize those who are living in a disguise through their own reprise

I am speaking of the various politicians who sit with First Nations and claim they are working towards the same goals and objectives. I feel as though these politicians are idolized and hailed as “good” Canadians. This is portrayed in mainstream media. The pride of Canada, pretending to be acting in good faith, when really politicians are more concerned with who the next donor will be for their campaign. We are repeatedly fed the same mantra from political groups in order to gain our vote. However, many of these are false promises that never come to fruition.

My ancestors lived off the land, now you wanna group us all into bands, all while ignoring all our demands

My father used to tell me stories of how back in his day, he would go hunting with his uncles in order to have moose for winter. My grandmother was a single mother raising three children by herself. If my dad and uncle did not bring anything home to eat then there was no meat for them to eat. My family used to hunt out of necessity. Whereas compared to now, my family rarely eats wild meats, as we have the means to afford a more colonial diet. I find this to be an ironic notion, because most of the grocery stores are full of ingredients that give my family diabetes. My father is also not as physically fit because he does not hunt, in combination with the grocery store diet, is ultimately impeding on his health and well being. However, this is what in the capitalist world, we supposedly strive for. Being grouped into bands that are a figment of the Indian Act reflects on how even our “First Nation governance” is a piece of the colonial tool. The last lyrics refer back to the previous lyrics in that our demands as Indigenous people are being ignored in favor of political and economic prosperity.

Cant oppress me I am a warrior, crowns got my nation being treated like a foreigner
I speak upon my spirit and my drive to fight for what is right. My lyrics go on to compare the strange feeling in which First Nations feel as they try and live in an urban colonial world, when

they may come from remote cultural communities. There is an element of stereotyping what it means to be a “foreigner”, however I compare this to the respect that Crown gives to Indigenous people. I am comparing the displacement aspect of being “foreign” to that of First Nation communities being placed on reservations.

Its real, since the creation, they have been moving us from location to location

I am speaking to the displacement of my own community, Fort William First Nation. This is reflecting on a time when we were moved from our territory along the shores of Lake Superior, to the inland and swamp where my reservation is now located. The graves of our ancestors were also dug up and moved to the swamp lands.

All the while, saving the good allocation, for those whom now want to say they have no obligation

In this lyric I am once again elaborating on the fact that my nation was displaced from our original area to what is now known as Fort William First Nation reserve. Now there are modern homes and residences where my ancestors once lived. The lyric reflects on notions of ignorance when those who now live on the land say they do not need to understand the history of my community. The feeling of entitlement from those who now live off the land that was taken from Indigenous people, whom have no responsibility to even respect Indigenous people.

Our rights are affirmed and recognized, our ancestors were presented this as if it were a prize
Not knowing the crowns tendency to lie
Little did they know we would be living subsidized

This lyric draws on the narrative that upon signing of many Treaties and agreements, colonists acted immorally. There have been many documented instances where Indigenous peoples were fed a false narrative in order for Europeans to gain control of their land. The last line is referring to how many First Nations people live in subsidized housing. Many First Nations live in poverty due to the deception of many key negotiations.

How can you look at us with such hate, and then expect us to believe you will fairly negotiate

I am now speaking upon the era in Indigenous and Crown relations. The one in which First Nations have been so deceived that they no longer trust the Crown. The relationship between the Crown and Indigenous peoples plays out within negotiations with corporations. The business endeavors regarding First Nation consultation is notoriously hostile because of the lack of trust First Nations have when it comes to negotiating. These are now deeply embedded in the minds of every Indigenous person when it comes to signing documents. Many Indigenous people scoff at the notion of “reconciliation”, and my opinion, rightfully so.

Trying to buy us off with the monetized paper, just so you can be the lands raper

This goes to the notion of being “paid off”. In that many ways, corporations in Canada, specifically in the natural resource sector, are able to wreak havoc on ecosystems and are simply punished with fines. This is seen throughout North America, in that corporations will continue to act without regard for environmental laws and just pay the legal expense. They do this because of their bottom line, which is profits for the shareholders. The notion of being able to just pay the courts fines and continue to blatantly cause harm to the land is a byproduct of capitalism.

I see my people staying loyal to the land, while others want to meet the oil market demand

I have been in the protests against the pipelines here in Vancouver. I have also met with and spoken to Indigenous leadership who want to exploit their lands for oil. I think it is a delicate balance of what is good for the environment, and what will be good for the community. I know though that the damage that we do to the land is irreversible, and we should weigh our decision with this heavy burden.

First out here

My ode to Indigenous peoples.

We are not considered equal, they still want to displace my people

The fact that I have a status card that I carry with me as a form of identifying myself leads me to conclude that we as Indigenous people are not in fact equal. The fact that my sister, who is both First Nation from her mother and father, has to choose what band she wants to be a part of. The displacement from the community she does not belong to, her mother's, does not give her voting capacity in that community. It will be difficult for to have a sense of belonging to that community, and this is all a decision that her parents are faced with as a result of the Indian Act.

All that we see in hollywood, is ever represented by those who have a tough time in manhood

There are many mainstream films that feature Indigenous binary male main characters. These films are well known, and pump into the patriarchy. The patriarchy was imposed on Indigenous people by colonialism. Many of the films that I have seen that depict Indigenous people, the main characters mostly are men. The only time I remember watching an Indigenous woman was in the Disney film Pocahontas. I would later learn that this was the story of a young woman being kidnapped and subsequently raped. This was not exactly the Disney love story I remembered.

Its not innate for us to compete and dominate

I am speaking about the spiritual nature that many First Nations communities, previous to settler contact. My people, the Ojibwa of Lake Superior, were focused on the Great Spirit and being the

guardians of the natural world. It is in my opinion that Ojibwa people lacked the greed that is common among colonial ways of being.

Our culture is not a costume, i just want back my family's heirlooms

I am speaking to the many costumes that are sold each year, that portray stereotypes of Indigenous people. I also speak to headdresses in particular, as many are now within possession of private entities. I recognize that headdresses are works of art, however they also hold much power and meaning to Indigenous people. I hope one day I am able to be in the presence of an ancestors headdress.

Justin Trudeau was tryna play games, Jody Wilson-Raybould was not about his fame

This line is in reference to the SNC Lavalin scandal. I believe that JWR acted responsibly and that Justin Trudeau was in the wrong. I was appalled that she was taken out of the Liberal party. I am proud of the grace and dignity that she exuded in her testimony and as a person. I met her once and she told me I would be the next Attorney General. I have held on to her words throughout some very dark times personally. I can honestly say that she will forever live in infamy within the Indigenous community. She is a warrior as well.

Legal profession claims they wanna see us out of oppression, but i'm out here stressin and investin, just tryna be the best dressin
Everytime i put on a suit i feel further and further from my roots,

These lyrics speak to the "but I was wearing a suit" campaign. There are stereotypes and bias that exist within the legal profession that are largely classist. Overcoming adversity in order to become an Indigenous lawyer is extremely difficult in itself, and then to be thrown into the judgmental legal profession can really be triggering. I wanted to reflect the imposter syndrome that many of my peers and I face when we walk into spaces and are the only Indigenous faces.

Yea, Its no wonder many of our women turn a trick and prostitute
Everytime I turn on the news, missing and murdered Indigenous women
And then I hear Adam Palmer tryna be dismissing
Defending and tryna diffuse
But we are still out here reminiscing, about all those who were abused

This verse reflects upon the dark reality many Indigenous women face in Canada today. Many Indigenous women are subject to commoditizing their bodies, with or without consent. This is a part of society that I hope I can work with and help change. Sex work is work, and Canada needs to recognize this in order to empower women. I call out the Vancouver Police Department, as they deny having a racial problem. I can't help but wonder what would have happened to all the cases of missing and murdered Indigenous women, had there not been this

complete lack of regard for their lives. Holding onto the memories of the missing is what keeps us human.

People wanna say I look white, I laugh because they dont know my fight
So i will go get my JD and live lavish, for all those who called me a fucking savage

I have been told by many people throughout my life that I do not appear to be First Nation. At this point in my life I can only laugh at the ignorance of their words. I also have been called a savage before, and those words do cut very deeply into my soul. This however is also my motivation to become a lawyer.